



85%

LITERACY RATE BY 2012 IS WHAT THE GOVERNMENT HOPES TO TARGET BY GIVING EMPHASIS TO EDUCATION IN ITS 11TH FIVE-YEAR PLAN.

making the bureaucracy more competent and enabling and so on.

Without doubt, each of these is crucial to achieve. However, I now want to focus on some aspects that will directly impact the three challenges I listed initially. These aspects are the pedagogic processes of exploration and dialogue; and the educational goals of empathy and independence.

Learning happens when children explore things and interpret what they encounter. The teacher facilitates this process by choosing what children explore and by influencing how they interpret. I would suggest that teachers choose issues that will create debates around issues of equity and inequity, respect and prejudice, and harmful versus sustainable lifestyles. For instance, the kinds of caste, class and religion-based stereotypes that exist

around us; garbage and its impact on ecology; or even the different ways in which hegemony operates.

Let us take the garbage example: this is something a government teacher has tried with his students. For homework, the teacher asked children to rummage through the dustbin, and make a list of waste items. The next day, the class explored three questions: What is waste? Why is it generated? And, what is the impact of each form of waste on the environment? Something as simple as the dustbin suddenly opened up a Pandora's box: the idea that waste is an exclusively human creation, that no other species on earth generates waste; that local products generate lesser waste than products that are processed, packaged and transported from distant areas;